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ENGLISH LANGUAGE · READING COMPREHENSION · DEMO NOTES

Finding the Main Idea

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1. What is the main idea?

The main idea is the **one central claim** the whole passage exists to support. Every paragraph, example and statistic in the passage is there to back it up.

Remember: the main idea is never a single detail and never a vague topic. It is a complete statement of what the author wants you to accept.

2. The 3-step method

1. **Read the edges.** Authors usually state or restate their point in the first and the last paragraph.
2. **Ask the question.** 'What is the author trying to prove?' Answer it in one sentence of your own before reading the options.
3. **Eliminate.** Reject options that are too narrow (only one detail), too broad (more than the passage covers) or off-topic.

3. Main idea vs topic vs detail

	Example (tree passage)	Is it the main idea?
Topic	Trees in cities	No — too vague
Detail	Trees lower summer temperatures	No — supports the point
Main idea	Trees are infrastructure and should be funded like it	Yes

4. Worked example

"Cities that plant more trees see lower summer temperatures, fewer heat-related hospital visits and calmer residents. Yet most municipal budgets treat trees as decoration rather

than infrastructure, funding them only after roads and drains."

Signal word: 'Yet' — the author turns from evidence to criticism. **Main idea:** trees deliver public benefits, so cities should fund them as infrastructure.

5. Practice question

Which option best states the main idea of the passage above?

(a) Trees make cities beautiful.
(b) Trees deliver public benefits and deserve infrastructure-level funding.
(c) Roads matter more than trees.
(d) Hospitals are crowded in summer.

Answer: (b). (a) is a detail the passage never makes, (c) reverses the author's view and (d) is a supporting detail.

6. Quick revision

- One passage, one central claim.
- Check the first and last paragraph first.
- Watch for signal words: yet, however, therefore, must.
- Too narrow or too broad = wrong option.